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ACADEMIC VAULT

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THA 214: Fundamentals of Script Writing - Structure, Character and Dialogue

Write a producible short play and learn to revise it

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Playwriting is a craft with repeatable techniques: premise, conflict, character want, escalation and resolution. This pack gives you a scene-by-scene method, dialogue exercises, formatting conventions and a revision checklist, ending with a ten-minute play brief you can actually complete.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Turn a premise into a dramatic conflict with stakes.
- Build a scene that has a clear want, obstacle and change.
- Write dialogue that performs character rather than explaining it.
- Format a script professionally and revise it through structured readings.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Premise, conflict, stakes

A play needs someone who wants something they cannot easily get.

- Premise: the situation in one sentence, including the disruption.
- Protagonist: the character who drives the action.
- Objective: what they want now, in this scene.
- Obstacle: the person or condition blocking them.
- Stakes: what happens if they fail.
- Theme emerges from the argument the play stages, not from a speech.

Scenes that turn

A scene earns its place by changing something.

- Enter late, leave early: start after the small talk and cut before the resolution.
- Give each character a distinct tactic, not just a distinct opinion.
- Escalate: each beat should raise cost or narrow options.
- Use subtext: characters rarely say exactly what they want.
- End the scene on a shift in power, knowledge or decision.
- Read dialogue aloud to catch lines no human would say.

> **Show, do not explain**
> If a character announces the theme, cut the line and let the action carry it. Audiences trust what they witness.

Format and revision

Standard formatting signals professionalism and speeds rehearsal.

- Scene headings, character names in capitals, dialogue, stage directions in italics or brackets.
- Keep stage directions minimal and physical.
- Number pages for rehearsal and timing.
- Hold a table read and mark where attention drops.
- Revise for clarity, not cleverness: cut ten percent.
- Keep drafts labelled with dates and version numbers.

A play is a machine for producing events

Beginning writers describe. Produced writers make things happen. The unit of a play is not the line but the event: something changes between the start and end of a scene, and the audience can name what changed. If a scene could be removed without altering anything later, it is not a scene; it is a conversation.

Structure in the practical sense is the arrangement of those changes so that each one makes the next one necessary. The traditional three-act shape and the five-act shape are descriptions of that pressure, not recipes. What matters is that the protagonist wants something, tries, fails in a way that raises the cost, and is finally forced to act in a way they would have avoided at the start.

Write the spine before the dialogue. One page: who wants what, who or what blocks it, what is at risk if they fail, and what the last image is. If you cannot write that page, no amount of dialogue will save the script, because you do not yet know what the scenes are for.

Dialogue is behaviour with words